

Master's Thesis Statement of Intent and Abstract

Submission deadline: See official form "Master Fine Arts Dates & Deadlines Autumn/Spring Term"

Last name, first name	Barton, Roger
If you could choose a mentor from the MFA faculty, who would this be?	Felix Stalder
Working title	A discourse on the impact of generative AI on human thinking.
Abstract (min. 500 characters)	The process of human thinking - reasoning, decision making - is becoming increasingly affected by the prevalence of generative AI models. AI models offer the capability to outsource cognition to handle the increasing complexities of today ' s world. This poses the questions: which forms of human cognition become obsolete? What significance of human cognition remains? Are new forms of human cognition emerging? The implications of this change are still very unclear and predictions are impeded by the rapid advancements of AI tools. Implementing rigorous studies to understand the underlying dynamics is time-consuming. Instead a more subjective, experimental discourse may be more suitable to quickly illuminate the various perspectives at play, while keeping some interaction with the scientific community. In this thesis, I would like to explore the different existing theories conversation with my own experiences.
Preliminary working hypothesis	The theories of thought [1] found in literature only partially match my own experiences. Recent theories include Storey [2] that proposes that the field of software engineering - a field most impacted by generative AI - is moving from the challenge of technical debt to that of cognitive and intent debt. The theory works on the basis of a collective group and implies that we no longer need to concern ourselves with technical implementations, but conversely with maintaining an overview and understanding our original intention. I hypothesise that this concept extends beyond that of software engineering to our individual thought processes. The cognition demanded of us in today ' s age is changing from calculating answers to finding them - we become reviewers. Furthermore, Shaw et al. [3] propose a Tri-System Theory, where the outsourcing of cognition to AI is introduced. The theory predicts a " cognitive surrender " of human judgement - adopting AI outputs with minimal scrutiny. Harari [4,5] proposes a similar concept that we have moved from secularism to humanism to dataism, where we trust more in data than our intuition. The notions of an oracle and blind faith and invite respective reading (tbc). I hypothesise that we can, in relevant cases, resist cognitive surrender.

Format	I suggest a discourse of different scientific papers and their perspectives on the topic in interaction with more subjective experimental writing of my own experiences. Potentially, the text may be in the form of a journal.
References/ bibliography	[1] “ Theories of thinking ” . (2026), https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Thought [2] Storey, Margaret-Anne. (2026). “ From Technical Debt to Cognitive and Intent Debt: Rethinking Software Health in the Age of AI ” . 10.48550/arXiv.2603.22106. [3] Shaw, Steven D., and Gideon Nave. (2026). " Thinking-Fast, Slow, and Artificial: How AI is Reshaping Human Reasoning and the Rise of Cognitive Surrender." Available at SSRN 6097646. [4] Harari, Y. N. (2016). “ Homo Deus ” . Harvill Secker. “ Chapter 11: Dataism ” [5] Harari, Y.N. (2017), “ Dataism Is Our New God ” . New Perspectives Quarterly, 34: 36-43. https://doi.org/10.1111/npqu.12080